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Will You Tolerate This? The Impact of Affective Commitment on Complaint Intention and Postrecovery Behavior

Heiner Evanschitzky¹, Christian Brock², and Markus Blut³

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Abstract

Successful complaint management primarily depends on customers' willingness to voice their complaints and on companies' ability to adequately deal with these complaints. This article investigates the impact of one relationship characteristic in the complaint management process: affective commitment. Based on two studies, the authors investigate whether affective commitment moderates the impact of complaint barriers on complaint intention (a) and whether it moderates the link between complaint satisfaction and purchase behavior after the complaint (b). Results show that affectively committed customers exhibit higher complaint intention irrespective of the level of complaint barriers. Furthermore, affectively committed customers display little change in their postrecovery behavior, even after a service failure followed by an unsatisfactory recovery attempt. It seems that these customers are tolerant and want to help the provider improve their business. Affective commitment seems to amplify willingness to help the company by means of voicing dissatisfaction despite considerable efforts in doing so. Moreover, affective commitment buffers the negative effects of service failures on postrecovery behavior. Findings have important implications for managers. They highlight the necessity to measure customers' affective commitment. Based on that, tailored complaint systems can be designed, which help in achieving a more effective allocation of resources for customer recovery.

Keywords

complaint management, complaint stimulation, complaint satisfaction, postrecovery behavior, affective commitment, double deviation effect

Commitment in buyer-seller relationships has been well established as a key factor in relationship development and continuity (Dwyer, Schurr, and Oh 1987; Morgan and Hunt 1994). It is defined as a customer's desire to build and sustain a valued relationship with a service provider or brand, and consists of both an affective and a calculative component (Fullerton 2003). Affective commitment consists of emotional attachment to, identification with, and involvement in an organization (Meyer and Allen 1991). It plays a vital role in explaining customer retention, switching intention, and positive word of mouth (WOM; Anderson and Weitz 1992; Bansal, Irving, and Taylor 2004; Bendapudi and Berry 1997; Evanschitzky et al. 2006; Fullerton 2003; Gwinner, Gremler, and Bitner 1998). While affective commitment has received considerable attention in the loyalty literature, little is known about its role in complaint management. This seems surprising because theories such as emotional attachment suggest that customers' desire to maintain a relationship would make them more likely to help a provider by complaining, and at the same time these customers are less likely to change behavior after negative incidents.

From a service provider's perspective, key objectives of complaint management are to reduce negative outcomes of service failures and to acquire information on flaws of the service delivery and thereby to prevent future service failures (e.g.,

Grainer 2003; Homburg and Fürst 2005). This entails (a) stimulating complaints and (b) providing a satisfactory recovery. While research has shown that up to 90% of customers do not voice their dissatisfaction to the provider (e.g., TARP 1979), it is surprising that only a relatively small number of studies have investigated the topic of complaint stimulation (e.g., Huppertz 2003; Owens and Hausknecht 1999). These studies generally show that complaining could be stimulated by reducing the effort of submitting a complaint (Bearden and Oliver 1985; Bearden and Teel 1980; Bodey and Grace 2006; Voorhees, Brady, and Horowitz 2006). However, there is more limited understanding of the effects of customer characteristics (such as customer attitudes and perceptions) and of relationship characteristics (such as affective commitment) on complaint intention (Table 1).

¹ Aston Business School, Marketing Group, Aston Triangle, Birmingham, UK

² Zeppelin University, Friedrichshafen, Germany

³ Department of Marketing, TU Dortmund University, Dortmund, Germany

Corresponding Author:

Heiner Evanschitzky, Aston Business School, Marketing Group, Aston Triangle, Birmingham B4 7ET, United Kingdom
Email: h.evanschitzky@aston.ac.uk

Table 1. Determinants of Complaint Intention

Determinant	Impact on Complaint Intention			Study
	Positive	Negative	Not Significant	
Customer characteristics				
Demographics				
Age		x		Bearden (1983); Gronhaug and Zaltman (1981)
Income	x		x	Bolfing (1989); Warland, Herrmann, and Willits (1975)
Education			x	Bearden (1983); Gronhaug and Zaltman (1981); Warland, Herrmann, and Willits (1975)
	x		x	Bolfing (1989)
			x	Bearden (1983)
	x			Gronhaug and Zaltman (1981); Warland, Herrmann, and Willits (1975)
Attitudes and perceptions				
Assertiveness/Self-confidence	x			Bearden (1983); Bolfing (1989)
Attitude toward complaining	x		x	Bodey and Grace (2007); Gronhaug and Zaltman (1981)
Psychological risk/risk taking	x			Blodgett, Wakefield, and Barnes (1995); Bodey and Grace (2007); Velazquez et al. (2006)
Information control/Coping potential	x			Bodey and Grace (2007)
(Perceived) likelihood of success	x			Mittal, Huppertz, and Khare (2008); Stephens and Gwinner (1998)
(Psychological or economic) Costs and benefits		x		Blodgett, Wakefield, and Barnes (1995); Richins (1983); Singh (1990a); Velazquez et al. (2006)
Trust (in other people)	x			Andreasen (1988); Day (1984); Voorhees, Brady and Horowitz (2006)
Redress seeking	x		x	Fornell and Didow (1980); Richins (1980)
(Past) shopping experience				Bearden (1983)
Level of dissatisfaction	x			Chebat, Davidow, Codjovi (2005)
Overall satisfaction	x			Singh and Pandya (1991); Zeelenberg and Pieters (2004)
Competence	x		x	Velazquez et al. (2006)
Product importance			x	Ping (1993)
Purchase frequency	x			Bearden (1983)
Relationship characteristics			x	Blodgett, Wakefield, and Barnes (1995); Shuptrine and Wenglorz (1981)
(Relational) tie strength		x		Fornell and Didow (1980)
Rapport			x	Mittal, Huppertz, and Khare (2008)
Marketplace characteristics				
Alternative provider			x	de Witt and Brady (2003)
Switching barriers	x			Andreasen (1985); Fornell and Didow (1980);Ping (1993)
				Ping (1993)

There is an apparent gap in the literature as, so far, only a few studies have examined the impact of relationship characteristics on complaint intention (de Witt and Brady 2003; Mittal, Huppertz, and Khare 2008), and none of these studies have examined the impact of one key relationship characteristic on complaint intention—that of affective commitment. Hence, our first objective is to investigate whether affective commitment influences the effectiveness of complaint stimulation.

Apart from stimulating customer complaints, the second goal of complaint management is handling customer complaints in a satisfactory manner (e.g., Fornell and Wernerfelt 1988). While a large number of studies have investigated the direct impact of organizational complaint handling on customer responses such as perceptions of justice, complaint satisfaction, attitudes, and intention (as summarized by two recent

meta-analyses: Gelbrich and Roschk 2011; Orsingher, Valentini, and de Angelis 2010), little is known about customer-related conditions (Orsingher, Valentini, and de Angelis 2010, p. 184), which may make complaint satisfaction a more or less important antecedent of future purchase intention and behavior.

As shown in Table 2, studies investigating relationship moderators in recovery-related contexts are rare and show contradictory effects. More specifically, Ganesan et al. (2010) find a buffering effect of affective commitment on switching intention in the case of mild misconduct of the provider and an amplifying effect in the case of severe misconduct. Grégoire, Tripp, and Legoux (2009) show that relationship quality buffers the desire for revenge but not the desire for avoidance. A study by Grégoire and Fisher (2008) demonstrates that

Table 2. Studies on the Moderating Effects of Relationship Characteristics in Recovery-Related Contexts

Study ^b	Design/Context	Independent Variable	Dependent Variable	Moderator	Findings		
					+(Amplifying Effect)	-(Buffering Effect)	Not Significant (No Effect)
Ganesan et al. (2010)	Experiment/b2b-context	Ethical violations/opportunism	Switching intention	Affective Commitment	x (severe misconduct)	x (mild misconduct)	
Grégoire, Tripp, and Legoux (2009)	Experiment/b2c-context (online)	No, normal, high recovery attempt	Desire for revenge	Relationship quality		x (normal recovery)	
Grégoire and Fisher (2008)	Experiment/b2c-context	Distributive, interactional, and procedural justice	Perceived betrayal	Relationship quality (trust, commitment, relationship satisfaction)	x		
Grégoire and Fisher (2006)	Field study/b2c-context	Relationship quality	Desire for retaliation	Firm's controllability of the failure	x (low)	x (high)	
Hess et al. (2003)	Experiment/b2c-context	Customers' expectation of relationship continuity	Customers' service recovery expectations	—		x ^a	
Mattila (2004)	Experiment/b2c-context	Poor versus excellent recovery	Repurchase intention	Affective commitment			x
Sajtos, Brodie, and Whittome (2010)	Field study/b2c-context	Severity of service failure	Attitude changes	—	x	x ^a (trust)	
Tax, Brown, and Chandrasekaran (1998)	Field study/b2c-context	(Dis)satisfaction with complaint handling	Trust and commitment	Prior positive experience			x

Note. ^a Direct effects.

^b Table contains only findings that are relevant for the present study.

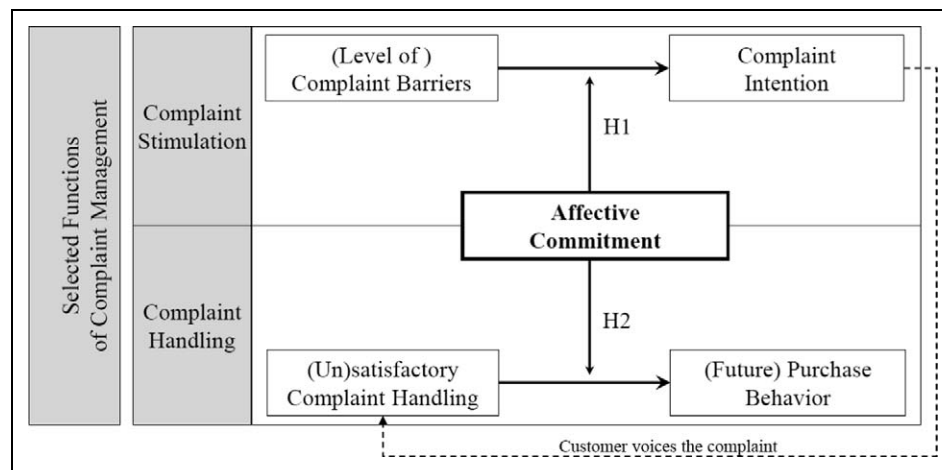


Figure 1. Conceptual model.

customers who perceive high levels of relationship quality feel more betrayed in cases where there are low levels of distributive and procedural fairness, indicating an amplifying effect of relationship characteristics. Finally, Mattila (2004) finds some evidence that highly committed customers do not change their attitude in cases of poor recovery. However, she did not find a significant interaction between affective commitment and quality of recovery on loyalty after the complaint. It is worth noting that the four previously mentioned studies are based on hypothetical incidents in lab settings and do not examine complaint satisfaction as an independent variable. Due to these limitations and mixed results, Mattila (2004) suggests the use of a real-life setting with longitudinal data (i.e., before and after the failure incident) as a fruitful area for future research.

We concur with Mattila (2004) in acknowledging the apparent gap in the literature related to better understanding the moderating role of relationship characteristics on the link between complaint handling and behavior after the complaint. To address this gap, the second primary objective of our study is to test the moderating role of affective commitment in explaining real customer behavior after a satisfying/nonsatisfying handling of a complaint following a real negative incident.

In summary, our research assesses the dual moderating role of affective commitment in a complaint management context. A better understanding of affective commitment and its impact on complaint stimulation and handling would help managers to allocate resources to those customers who are most likely to respond to stimulation and recovery activities. Accordingly, in Study 1 (complaint stimulation) we investigate the interplay between affective commitment, complaint barriers, and complaint intentions. In Study 2 (complaint handling), we assess whether different behavioral reactions to post service failure experiences are contingent upon affective commitment. In the next section, we introduce the theoretical background that justifies the moderating effects of affective commitment in the complaint management process. We then present results of the two studies and discuss the implications of our findings.

Theoretical Background and Hypotheses

Our discussion of the impact of affective commitment in complaint management is based on Hirschman's (1970) theory of exit, voice, and loyalty and on emotional attachment theory (Bowlby 1979). Figure 1 summarizes the conceptual model and the two hypotheses of our research.

Affective Commitment, Complaint Barriers, and Complaint Intention

Researchers highlight Hirschman's (1970) theory of exit, voice, and loyalty as the basic framework for explaining customer reaction after service failures, especially for explaining why some customers voice their dissatisfaction while others remain silent (e.g., Blodgett, Granbois, and Walters 1993). Hirschman proposes three levels to explain the specific response style of dissatisfied customers. Level I discusses in detail the different options for response styles of dissatisfied customers and provides three options: (a) exit, (b) voice, and (c) loyalty. Level II investigates the role of individual customer characteristics and suggests that complaining behavior depends mainly on the costs and benefits of voicing the complaint, the probability that the complaint will be successful, and the ability and the willingness to take up the voice option. Level III includes industry characteristics and differentiates between three scenarios within any given industry: competitive, monopolistic, and loose monopoly (Singh 1990b).

As our study investigates the role of affective commitment in the complaint management process, it primarily taps into Hirschman's *Level II*, as it specifically considers customer characteristics that might influence complaint behavior. The decision to opt for exit, voice, or loyalty is contingent upon personal characteristics, traits, and/or attitudes that define the relationship between customer and provider (Hirschman 1970).

Complaint barriers are obstacles (e.g., time and perceived costs) customers have to overcome to complain (Lovelock and

Wirtz 2007; Sbaraini and Carpenter 1996). Several studies suggest that a reduction of these complaint barriers increases customers' willingness to voice dissatisfaction after a failure (Bearden and Teel 1980; Voorhees, Brady, and Horowitz 2006). Reference to exit, voice, and loyalty theory (Hirschman 1970) makes this suggestion appear sensible: a reduction of complaint barriers reduces the perceived costs of voicing the dissatisfaction and, consequently, makes complaining more likely.

However, some customers may take the "voice" option when complaint barriers are high. They might do so because of a sense of being part of the firm and as an attempt to take part in the firm's practices—in short, because of their affective commitment. Complaining, in that sense, can be seen as a way for (affectively committed) customers to engage with the company in order to maintain a valued relationship and to attempt to improve outcome quality (Achrol 1997; Allen and Meyer 1990; Bendapudi and Berry 1997; Hirschman 1970). Literature indicates that one motivation for complaining is to help the provider to improve service quality (Bark et al. 1994; Lovelock and Wirtz 2007). This argument is in line with emotional attachment theory, which suggests that customers want to help in order to sustain a valued relationship, despite the substantial effort required to do so (Bowlby 1979).

Based on attachment theory, therefore, we assume that affectively committed customers are more likely to voice their dissatisfaction, irrespective of the effort involved in doing so. Conversely, in the presence of relatively high complaint barriers, customers who do not care about the company might not complain. We do not expect customers with low levels of affective commitment to attempt to change or improve the company's practices, because they do not have a strong feeling of connection to the company. Therefore, their likely reaction after a service failure—and in the presence of relatively high complaint barriers—would be to *not* register a complaint. More likely, these customers would terminate the relationship, thereby taking the "exit" option (Huppertz 2003). Hence, we assume:

Hypothesis 1: Affective commitment will moderate the impact of complaint barriers on complaint intention: Customers displaying high levels of affective commitment will complain irrespective of complaint barriers, whereas customers with low levels of affective commitment will only complain when complaint barriers are low.

Affective Commitment, Complaint Satisfaction, and Purchase Behavior

In general, research on customers' *behavioral* reactions after service failures and recovery attempts is sparse. Most studies use proxy measures for behavior, such as purchase intention or self-reported behavior as dependent variables (de Matos, Henrique, and Rossi 2007; Orsingher, Valentini, and de

Angelis 2010). These studies provide wide agreement that customer reactions after unsuccessful recovery attempts are negative. Findings show that low levels of complaint satisfaction intensify customer dissatisfaction and cause repurchase intention to plummet (e.g., Bitner, Booms, and Tetreault 1990; Hart, Heskett, and Sasser 1990).

However, there is less agreement on how customers react after successful recovery attempts. Some research finds evidence for the "service recovery paradox," meaning that levels of satisfaction and repurchase intention after a service failure and a successful recovery exceed prefailure level, while other empirical studies do not report such an effect (de Matos, Henrique, and Rossi 2007). Mixed findings are possibly due to the measurement of the dependent variable (self-reported vs. actual behavior) or to the presence of intervening factors such as justice perceptions.

In all, knowledge about behavioral reactions after service failure and recovery attempts is limited, with lack of consideration of moderating effects as a likely reason. As shown above, relationship characteristics might play an important (moderating) role in better understanding postrecovery reactions. In particular, the question of the moderating impact of affective commitment on the link between complaint satisfaction and purchase behavior warrants attention. Previous research has not clearly established whether a recovery attempt causes different postrecovery behavioral reactions contingent upon the level of a customer's affective commitment. To better understand these postrecovery behavioral reactions, we draw on emotional attachment theory (Bowlby 1969; Perlman and Fehr 1987).

Emotional attachment theory states that customers seek proximity to another person or object (i.e., a service provider) they feel affectively committed to. They would even tolerate failures and continue to purchase from the provider in order to maintain a feeling of security and proximity. Hence, negative incidents might not necessarily lead to negative reactions. We would expect affective commitment to moderate the complaint satisfaction-purchase behavior link: while customers with lower levels of affective commitment may reduce future purchases, or stop buying altogether, from a provider giving unsuccessful service recovery after an initial failure, highly affectively committed customers may choose *not* to take the "exit" option, even after an unsatisfactory recovery attempt. We expect customers high in affective commitment to be more tolerant in the case of service failure. We would expect them to make further attempts to continue their valued relationship with the service provider.

Hypothesis 2: Affective commitment will moderate the impact of complaint satisfaction on future purchase behavior: customers displaying high levels of affective commitment will not change their postfailure/recovery purchase behavior, irrespective of satisfaction with complaint handling, whereas customers with low levels of affective commitment will reduce future purchases if they are not satisfied with complaint handling.

In the subsequent sections, we test our hypotheses with two studies. Study 1 is a scenario-based experiment and Study 2 draws from actual purchase behavior (before and after a real service failure) combined with survey-based measures of commitment and complaint satisfaction of customers of a service provider. The combination of both studies with their respective methodologies allows us to achieve high level of internal validity as well as external validity by using behavioral data in a real-life setting.

Study 1

Method

Study 1 uses an experimental design to investigate the effects of affective commitment and complaint barriers on complaint intention. To test the moderating effect of affective commitment on the link between complaint barriers and complaint intention (Hypothesis 1), we employ a 2 (low vs. high affective commitment) $\times$ 2 (low vs. high complaint barriers) between-subjects design. We chose a fast-food restaurant setting primarily because this industry is characterized by a high number of potential complaint incidents. Moreover, the situation described in the scenarios is very familiar to student subjects, and the levels of affective commitment are widespread. The participants in this study were undergraduate students of a large university in Germany.

Based on a set of pretests, we developed manipulations for the independent variables of our study. In order to manipulate affective commitment, we selected real brands with high and low levels of customer commitment (Pretest 1). We extended the manipulation by adding written scenarios which provide additional reasons for being affectively committed (or not) to the two brands selected (Pretest 2). A subsequent test of the affective commitment scenarios with 46 participants (56.5% females, average age 24.3 [$SD = 1.86$]) resulted in significantly different levels of affective commitment (mean difference of 2.42; $F = 30.534$; $p < .01$). Based on a third pretest, the level of complaint barriers was manipulated with a written scenario. Overall, we asked 74 participants (40.0% females, average age 25.3 [$SD = 3.44$]) to indicate the perceived level of complaint barriers. Results exhibit a significant difference in means of 2.57 ($F = 38.142$; $p < .01$). Finally, we established the importance of controlling for severity and value of the failure (e.g., Shuptrine and Wenglortz 1981; TARP 1979). While the choice of a relatively low value of the complaint object may negatively affect an individuals' complaint intention, a relatively high value should have a positive effect. To control for these effects, we had to designate value and severity of the failure in such a way that it would make individuals feel indifferent regarding a potential complaint. Based on 142 interviews (51.3% females, average age 24.8 [$SD = 2.50$]), we selected a value of 7.50 € in our final written scenarios. Furthermore, we presented different kinds of service failures (e.g., incorrect billing, lukewarm food, long wait time, etc.) and asked for

probability of complaining, as well as perceived severity of the failure (in line with Richins 1983). Based on results of Pretest 4, lukewarm food was chosen as the failure scenario for the main experiment.

The sample for the main experiment comprised of 146 student subjects; 54.2% were females and the average age was 26.8 ($SD = 6.20$). Each subject was randomly assigned to one of the four scenarios and received identical instructions for answering the questions. None of the subjects seemed to have any difficulty in understanding the scenarios or answering the questions. Moreover, all subjects agreed that a situation as described in the scenario was realistic and that they had experienced similar situations (see Appendix A for the scenarios).

Conceptualization and items for measuring the constructs, using multi-item Likert-type scales, were adapted from prior research in the service, complaint, and commitment literature. We used 3 items from Singh (1990b) to measure the propensity for complaint after the service failure (Cronbach's α : .76; composite reliability [CR]: .86). Affective commitment was measured using 3 items suggested by Gustafsson, Johnson, and Roos (2005; Cronbach's α : .85; CR: .91). In order to perform a manipulation check of the perceived level of complaint barriers, we used 1 item from Blodgett, Granbois, and Walters (1993) and added two context-specific items (Cronbach's α : .81; CR: .89).

Because attitude toward complaining is a significant predictor in distinguishing between complainers and noncomplainers (e.g., Blodgett, Granbois, and Walters 1993; Voorhees, Brady, and Horowitz 2006), it is a sensible choice for a control variable in our study. Attitude toward complaining was measured by 4 items suggested by Voorhees, Brady, and Horowitz (2006; Cronbach's α : .71; CR: .88).

Scale items, psychometric properties, and the correlations between all Study 1 constructs are provided in Tables 3 and 4. Discriminant validity was evident, since the variance extracted for each pair of factors was greater than the square of the correlation between each of those two factors (Fornell and Larcker 1981; Hair et al. 2006).

Results and Discussion

First, it can be noted that both manipulations were successful and in the expected direction. The difference in means between the high and low complaint barrier scenarios was 1.77 ($F = 47.192$; $p < .01$) and the difference in means for the affective commitment scenarios was 1.47 ($F = 26.836$; $p < .01$).

In order to test Hypothesis 1, we conducted an analysis of covariance. We find support for two direct effects. Both the level of complaint barriers and the level of affective commitment have a direct effect on complaint intention. More interestingly, we find a significant interaction effect between affective commitment and the level of complaint barriers ($F = 3.263$, $p < .05$). Hence, we find support for Hypothesis 1 (see Figure 2). The control variable, attitude toward complaining, was also significant ($F = 16.301$; $p < .01$).

Table 3. Scale Items and Psychometric Properties

Construct/Item	Cronbach's α	CR	Source
<i>Complaint Intention</i> ^a			
I will forget the incident and do nothing. (reverse coded)	.76	.86	Singh (1990b)
I will definitely complain.			
I will complain immediately after the incident.			
<i>Affective Commitment</i> ^b			
I take pleasure in being a customer of the company.	.85	.91	Gustafsson, Johnson, and Roos (2005)
I have feelings of trust toward the company.			
The company is the operator that takes the best care of their customers.			
<i>Perceived Level of Complaint Barriers</i> ^b			
It is easy to voice a complaint toward the provider.	.81	.89	Context-specific items
The provider eases the voicing of dissatisfaction.			
This provider encourages its customers to complain about items that they are not satisfied with.			Blodgett, Granbois, and Walters (1993)
<i>Attitude toward complaining</i> ^a			
It bothers me if I do not complain about an unsatisfactory purchase.	.71	.88	Voorhees, Brady, and Horowitz (2006)
It feels good to get my dissatisfaction off my chest by complaining.			
I like to complain.			
I like people who complain to firms.			

Note. CR = composite reliability.

^a Measured using 7-point Likert-type scales anchored by "strongly agree/strongly disagree".

^b Measured using 9-point Likert-type scales anchored by "strongly agree/strongly disagree".

In summary, results suggest that for customers with lower levels of affective commitment, reducing complaint barriers increases complaint intention, whereas for customers with high levels of affective commitment, complaint barriers do not affect intention to complain. We acknowledge, however, that highly affectively committed customers exhibit higher levels of complaint intention, irrespective of the level of complaint barriers. These findings are in line with our theoretical predictions, suggesting that committed customers would take action to help improve a company's practices by, for instance, complaining.

Study 2

Method

After having found a significant interaction between affective commitment and complaint barriers in Study 1, we use Study 2

Table 4. Correlation Matrix and Average Variance Extracted (AVE)

	1	2	3	4	AVE
1. Attitude toward complaining	1				.522
2. Complaint intention	.398	1			.682
3. Complaint barriers	.179	.238	1		.731
4. Affective commitment	-.038	.094	.345	1	.771

to assess the remaining links in the conceptual model. We test whether affective commitment moderates the impact of customer satisfaction with complaint handling (complaint satisfaction) on actual purchase behavior (Hypothesis 2).

To test the hypothesis, a 2 (low vs. high affective commitment) $\times$ 2 (low vs. high complaint satisfaction) between-subjects design has been employed. To measure the variables for Study 2, we use two sources of data. First, we use survey data: customers from a fast-food delivery service provider were interviewed as part of the company's regular customer survey. Telephone interviews were conducted with 9,461 customers. Among other questions, customers were asked about their level of affective commitment to the service provider, using the scale from Gustafsson, Johnson, and Roos (2005; Cronbach's α : .84; CR: .90). In line with Maxham and Netemeyer (2002), we told the participants to think retrospectively about their experience and relationship with the service provider. We then asked about their overall level of affective commitment and assessed any negative incident experienced by them in the last 6 months. Overall, 388 customers (4.1% of all customers) reported having experienced a recent negative experience. Main reasons for complaints were a wrong or incomplete delivery (33.9%), followed unsatisfactory food quality (taste; 31.3%), long waiting time (14.2%), and lukewarm food (13.5%). Furthermore, approximately 7% of the complaints included reasons such as wrong billing or rude employees. Of the 388 customers that experienced a negative incident, 233 customers complained to the service provider, typically via phone to the service employee (accounting for 60.1% "complainers"). The 233 complainers were then asked about their satisfaction with the service provider's recovery attempt, for which we use a scale adapted from Maxham and Netemeyer (2003), Homburg and Fürst (2005), and Tax, Brown, and Chandrashekar (1998). Reliability and validity are within acceptable boundaries (Cronbach's α : .96; CR: .96).

Table 5 provides descriptive statistics for the complete database.

By means of median splits on complaint satisfaction (cutoff: 3.51) and affective commitment (cutoff: 3.59), we created four groups, with the smallest consisting of 48 cases. Because of unequal cell sizes in conjunction with absence of variance homogeneity, we created (by random deletion) four cells of equal size for a final sample of $4 \times 48 = 192$ subjects.

In addition to the attitudinal data, which was based on a customer survey, we were granted access to the purchase history of the service provider's customers. More precisely, we had access to purchase data from the time of a customer's first transaction with the firm until 6 months after the reported

Table 5. Descriptive Statistics

	No Incident (<i>n</i> = 9,073)	Noncomplainers (<i>n</i> = 155)	Complainers (<i>n</i> = 233)
Average age	32.1	29.6	30.6
Female (%)	58.4	61.0	53.6
Male (%)	41.6	39.0	46.4
Income bracket (%)			
0–1,000 €	27.6	25.8	30.0
1,000 €–2,000 €	35.0	38.7	32.0
2,000 €–3,000 €	20.7	17.2	17.3
>3,000 €	16.7	18.3	20.7
Marital status (%)			
Single	52.4	47.4	55.2
Married	47.6	52.6	44.8
Purchase behavior ^a			
Average purchase amount	16.54	16.69	17.16
Average number of purchases per year	20.83	21.44	22.15

Note. ^a None of the differences between the figures in each row are significant.

Table 6. Study 2 ANOVA Statistics

	Degrees of Freedom	<i>F</i> Value	Significance
Complaint satisfaction	1	2.799	<.05
Affective commitment	1	3.013	<.05
Complaint satisfaction × affective commitment	1	2.778	<.05
Error	188		
Total	192		

Note. ANOVA = analysis of variance.

negative incident. Using these data, we calculate the change in a customer's average spending per purchase after the negative incident as the percentage change of the average amount spent per purchase after the negative incident, compared to the amount spent before the negative incident¹ (with a positive algebraic sign indicating an increase in sales for the 6 months after the incident and a negative algebraic sign signifying a decrease in sales).

Results and Discussion

First, we note that correlations between constructs are relatively low (affective commitment-complaint satisfaction: .062; affective commitment-behavior: .102; complaint satisfaction-behavior: .101). Table 6 provides *F* statistics for Study 2.

The analysis of variance (ANOVA) with “percentage change in purchase volume after negative incident” as the dependent variable revealed that complaint satisfaction has a positive impact on actual future purchase behavior. We first compared means of the dependent variable for successfully recovered customers (high complaint satisfaction) and unsuccessfully recovered customers (low complaint satisfaction). Results indicate that, on average, customers with low levels of complaint satisfaction will reduce their purchase volume by 19.10% after such an unsuccessful recovery attempt, whereas successfully recovered customers do not substantially

change their behavior, indicated by a marginal (yet insignificant) increase in their purchase volume by .16%. The difference in change of purchase volume between these two complaint satisfaction groups (.16 vs. 19.10) is significant at the .05 level ($F = 2.799$). These results refer to all customers, irrespective of their level of affective commitment.

Next, by including the moderator affective commitment (Hypothesis 2), we conducted further analyses into the effect of complaint satisfaction on purchase behavior. In order to test Hypothesis 2, we conducted an ANOVA with “percentage change in purchase volume after service failure” as the dependent variable and “complaint satisfaction” and “affective commitment” as independent variables. Results indicate that there is a significant interaction effect between complaint satisfaction and affective commitment ($F = 2.778, p < .05$).²

Follow-up ANOVAs displayed in Figure 3 show that customers high in affective commitment do not exhibit a substantial change in their postfailure purchase behavior, irrespective of their satisfaction with the company's recovery effort (−2.38% and +3.09%). Conversely, we observed a large and significant difference in purchase behavior between the two groups of customers with lower levels of affective commitment: If the recovery attempt after a negative incident was perceived as satisfactory, the negative effect of the service failure can be reduced and the level of sales remains almost unchanged, as compared to the situation before the negative incident (−2.77%). If the recovery attempt is perceived as unsatisfactory, however, customers with lower levels of affective commitment will substantially reduce their purchase volume with the service provider (by −35.82%). The difference between these two means is significant (−2.77 and −35.82, $p < .01$).³

The finding that affectively committed customers do not significantly change their behavior even after two failures—the double deviation of an initial service failure and failed recovery attempt—might suggest that these customers do not require much of the company's attention and resource investments in recovering them. However, behavioral changes may not be the

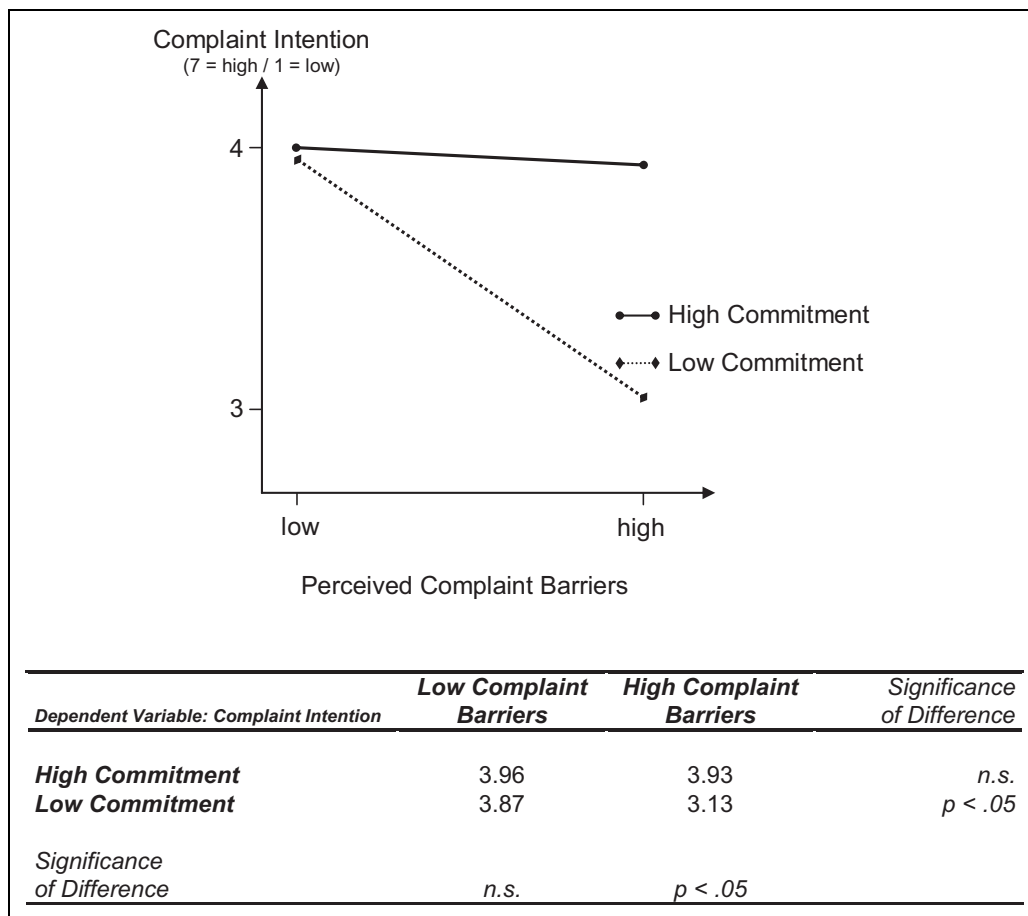


Figure 2. Study 1: Affective commitment, complaint barriers, and complaint intention (Hypothesis 1).

only consequences of such a double deviation. The literature in particular finds effects of failures on (negative) WOM (e.g., Anderson 1998; Richins 1983). Therefore, we did a follow-up analysis with the same set of complainers as used for Study 2 (192 subjects) to assess the impact of failed recovery attempts on one important customer intention: WOM. While highly affectively committed customers apparently do not change their behavior, we discovered that the likelihood of spreading negative WOM increases substantially, from 3.89 to 4.43 ($F = 6.26$; $p < .01$), when their complaint satisfaction is low. We also found a significant decrease in the likelihood of speaking positively about the company (2.70 to 1.93; $F = 8.37$; $p < .01$). These findings somewhat balance the nonsignificant impact of failures on behavior for affectively committed customers.

Discussion

Summary of Findings

The primary purpose of our two studies was to provide new insight into the role of affective commitment in two important phases of the complaint management process: (a) complaint stimulation and (b) complaint handling. In assessing the dual moderating role of affective commitment, we respond to a recent call for research on factors influencing the effectiveness

of complaint management by assessing the role of customer attitudes in greater detail (Orsingher, Valentini, and de Angelis 2010, p. 184).

The Role of Affective Commitment for Complaint Stimulation

Results of Study 1 indicate that affective commitment positively influences complaint intention and complaint barriers pose a negative influence. While these effects are as expected, we find a significant interaction effect between affective commitment and the level of complaint barriers on complaint intention. The effect indicates that customers high in affective commitment complain irrespective of the presence of complaint barriers, whereas customers with low levels of commitment do not complain when being presented with high complaint barriers. This indicates that affective commitment, a key variable describing the relationship between provider and customer, plays a major role in complaint stimulation. One might speculate that customers low in affective commitment focus more on redress seeking. If these customers are unsure about the level of compensation or the service failure is rather unimportant to them, they do not complain. Conversely, we assume that high affectively committed customers voice their dissatisfaction to improve the services.

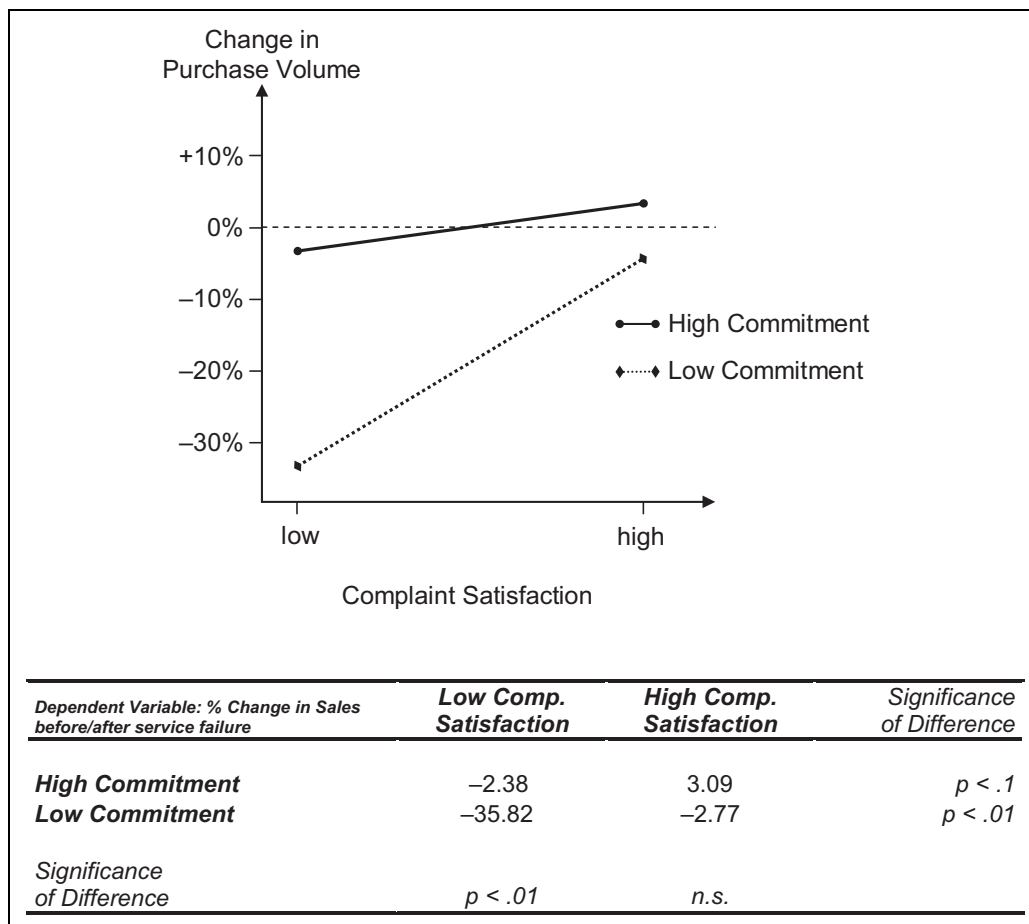


Figure 3. Study 2: Complaint satisfaction, affective commitment, and purchase behavior (Hypothesis 2).

Hence, for these customers maintaining and improving the relationship is of key importance.

The Role of Affective Commitment for Complaint Handling and Repurchase Behavior

First, it can be noted that complaint satisfaction is likely to influence postrecovery behavior. We find that an unsuccessful recovery reduces future spending with the provider, while a successful recovery attempt stabilizes future purchase behavior. Second, we find that affectively committed customers seem to be tolerant, even after repeated failures. That means that no matter how good—or how unfavorable—a recovery attempt by a service provider is, postfailure/recovery behavior changes only mildly. Conversely, customers with low levels of affective commitment need to perceive a recovery as satisfactory in order to continue purchasing from the provider at a level similar to that before the service failure. For these customers, however, an unsatisfactory recovery attempt significantly reduces future purchase behavior. It seems that highly affectively committed customers focus more on the overall relationship with the provider while low affectively committed customers focus on the transactional aspect of complaint satisfaction.

Contribution to Complaint Management Research

Results of this study broaden our understanding of the role of affective commitment in the complaint management context. Recent research suggests that a better understanding of moderating factors in complaint management has the potential to help managers to segment their customer base and to better differentiate complaint management operations (Orsingher, Valentini, and de Angelis 2010). Our study finds affective commitment to be such a moderating factor.

More precisely, we first uncover that affective commitment amplifies complaint intention despite the time and effort required to voice the complaint. This finding highlights the importance of relationship characteristics for complaint stimulation. Apparently, affective commitment is important not only in explaining relationship continuation but also in explaining customers' intention to complain, which can be interpreted as an attempt to help the provider. Therefore, our study is the first that confirms the importance of affective commitment for complaint stimulation.

Second, affective commitment buffers the impact of a service failure as well as a failed recovery. Not even the double deviation of two consecutive failures (i.e., initial service failure and failed recovery attempt) seems to prompt negative consequences for purchase behavior of customers with high levels

Table 7. Sequential Recovery Efforts Contingent upon Commitment Levels

	Short-Term Activities	Long-Term Activities
High Affective Commitment	Rectifying failure	Thanking for feedback and showing how it helped improving service operations
	No overcompensation Encouraging feedback on the failure	Encourage engagement in customer communities
Low Affective Commitment	Rectify failure	Follow-up calls to assess postrecovery satisfaction
	Spend extra resources on recovery	Highlighting ways to interact with the provider and its customers
	Immediate redress	

of affective commitment. Possibly, behavior of affectively committed customers is much more stable than previously anticipated. Our study extends previous research by confirming affective commitment to be of importance for complaint handling. Previous studies by Mattila (2004) and Ganesan et al. (2010) do not find such an effect. The reason for that might be that Mattila (2004) used hypothetical situations in experimental settings. Possibly, subjects did not truly feel committed toward the provider. Moreover, she examined a different independent variable (recovery quality) compared to our study. Ganesan et al. (2010) also chose lab settings and a different context (ethical misbehavior of firms), which may be the reasons for differing findings.

From a theoretical perspective, our finding suggests that in service settings characterized by low levels of switching barriers, low value of the complaint object, and failures of relatively low severity, we should expect a buffering effect of affective commitment on negative postfailure behavioral reactions instead of an amplifying effect. Purchase behavior of committed customers is very stable and relatively unaffected by negative incidents. Noting the suggestion of Ganesan et al. (2010) that in other industries with high levels of switching barriers, a high value of the complaint object, and a failure of relatively high severity, the buffering effect may turn into an amplifying effect, our study contributes to a better understanding of boundary conditions for postfailure attitudes and behavioral changes.

Implications for Service Managers

It is apparent from our results that service managers should be aware of differences in customers' reactions contingent upon individuals' level of affective commitment. Managers are therefore faced with the challenges of (a) identifying affectively uncommitted customers, (b) designing complaint systems tailored for different customer groups, and (c) effectively allocating resources for customer recovery.

First, in order to identify affectively (un)committed customers, companies would ideally conduct annual customer surveys

in which they include some items on affective commitment. In this way they would be able to track commitment levels over time. Moreover, affective commitment levels could be related to some easily observable variables such as sociodemographics, relationship characteristics, or customer behaviors. Companies that have a loyalty program in place could, for instance, link affective commitment to relationship duration in order to test whether new customers display lower levels of commitment than customers who have been with the provider for an extended time. Similarly, behavioral patterns (for instance, those measured by a customer's purchase frequency) might also be indicative of affective commitment. As behavioral data are available on a daily basis while affective commitment might be assessed only once a year, identifying correlates of affective commitment is key to better management of service failures.

Second, after having detected customers low in affective commitment, a strategy to motivate them to complain is to identify, and then reduce, their specific complaint barriers. Typical barriers include inconvenience (e.g., difficulty finding the right complaint procedure and the effort required to write a letter), uncertain payoffs (e.g., uncertainty whether any action will be taken by the firm to recover the customer, or what those actions might be), and unpleasantness associated with filing a complaint (e.g., fear of being treated rudely or being harassed; Lovelock and Wirtz 2007). Approaches to reducing these complaint barriers include making feedback easy, convenient, and if necessary, impersonal, by offering service hotlines, e-mail feedback forms, and postal addresses on all customer communication material. Moreover, providers may communicate a sincere interest in customer feedback through practices such as training frontline service employees to emphasize this concern. The provider might also proactively contact uncommitted customers to enquire whether something unsatisfactory occurred during their purchases.

Third, once customers have been motivated to complain after a failure, the provider needs to undertake actions to recover them. Our findings show that different levels of affective commitment should result in different measures for dealing with complaining customers. With limited marketing budgets in mind, we suggest a sequential recovery strategy.

First of all, committed customers are very valuable for company performance. However, while committed customers deserve much attention, service providers should not forget the uncommitted customers—which they sometimes appear to do. Companies might think about different (possibly low cost) measures of recovery for uncommitted customers and should calculate carefully for each customer, whether they once spent more resources (e.g., time and effort) on recovery than they would usually do for this group of customers. Such a calculation would take the postfailure/recovery behavior into consideration. Essentially, companies could decide on how many resources to devote on recovery efforts by calculating the potential losses in revenues after failure. Since our results show that committed customers do not change their behavior even after two failures, while uncommitted customers' behavior

changes dramatically, it makes economic sense to spend more resources on uncommitted customers in the *short run*.

In the *long run*, however, companies have to take other (negative) side effects of failures into consideration. Our follow-up analysis points to one important side effect: negative WOM. While committed customers do not change their behavior even after a double deviation, their likelihood of spreading negative WOM significantly increases. It is beyond the scope of our research, but others (e.g., Wangenheim and Bayón 2007) have shown the economic value of WOM. In line with their findings, we caution managers not to simply “shower money” on uncommitted customers. Even though it takes more efforts (i.e., money/resources) to retain uncommitted customers after a failure than committed ones, our findings suggest investing these resources is sensible because otherwise, the customer is likely switching for good (as indicated by an average drop in purchase volume of uncommitted customers by about one third). Once the imminent threat of switching has been dealt with, measures to increase commitment need to be employed—for the already committed just as for the uncommitted.

We would therefore suggest a sequential (i.e., short run; long run) approach to deal differently with different customers (i.e., affectively uncommitted and committed ones) after service failures. Table 7 shows potentially successful recovery efforts in sequential order, contingent upon customers’ affective commitment levels.

In the short run, providers should indeed spend extra resources to rectify failures experienced by uncommitted customers. Creating a satisfactory perception of the recovery is key to preventing immediate drops in purchase volume of uncommitted customers. One could think of measures like an instant, personal recovery call, and a hustle-free redress.

As for committed customers, we would suggest rectifying the failure without overcompensating while at the same time reinforcing the sense of belonging to the provider. Measures such as providing an adequate compensation for the failure, sincerely apologizing, and inviting the customer to help improving the service operations by explaining exactly what went wrong and how the company could change in order to prevent similar failures in the future would likely deliver that.

In the long run, that is, once the immediate failure has been dealt with, commitment of both customer groups should be enhanced. The previously uncommitted customers could be told that they are in fact very valuable customers—which has been evidenced by the extra recovery efforts by the company. This would likely increase their commitment postrecovery. The already committed customers’ positive attitudes should be reinforced by pointing out the good relationship they have with the provider. To further enhance commitment, providers could help in establishing brand communities (e.g., on Facebook or Twitter) that will support information exchange between the provider and customers. This would likely strengthen identification and shared values, belongingness, and dedication, all enhancing affective commitment. Such enhancement of affective commitment levels for customers is quite important as commitment may give the provider a second chance to win

back customers. It represents an “insurance” against defection when customers experience a service failure and an unsatisfactory recovery.

Ultimately, our findings suggest that after having dealt with the immediate effects of failures, companies should invest in customer commitment because it increases the likelihood of complaining and buffers the impact of a failed recovery, both of which make managing customers in the future more successful.

Limitations and Further Research

Despite our additional findings on the dual moderating role of affective commitment, several unanswered questions remain, suggesting the necessity of further investigation. First, our study contexts (fast-food restaurant in Study 1 and fast-food delivery service in Study 2) are characterized by low levels of switching barriers, a low value of the complaint object, and a failure of relatively low severity. Therefore, future research is needed to validate the moderating effect of affective commitment in different service sectors. In our study, we found a key relationship characteristic to amplify willingness to help the company through voicing dissatisfaction through complaints, and at the same time to buffer the negative effects of service failures on postrecovery behavior. It is unclear whether the amplifying effect of affective commitment in the first phase (and the buffering effect in the second phase) still holds for different setting, for example, high value of complaint object, or whether we find a reverse effect.

Second, affective commitment and complaint satisfaction were measured within one time period. Therefore, future research should measure affective commitment based on a panel analysis prior to the negative incident.

Third, the loyalty literature (e.g., Seiders et al. 2005) indicates that further variables such as location convenience, inertia, calculative and normative commitment, and switching costs might have similar moderating effects in the complaint management process. Therefore, we suggest empirically testing the role of these variables in the phases of complaint stimulation and complaint handling. A preliminary speculation might be that only high levels of affective commitment would lead customers to react less negatively, while calculative commitment might prevent them from switching but would not increase their complaint intention.

Fourth, our model considers a few, yet central variables of the complaint management process. It would be worth investigating more complex models which would also include fairness perceptions, with the speculation that affective commitment would moderate the relationship between the organizational response to the complaint and the fairness dimensions which mediate between the response and satisfaction.

Fifth, useful observations could be made from analysis of the potential interaction effects between complaint barriers and affective commitment, as well as between affective commitment and complaint satisfaction, and their impact on other dependent variables. For instance, we assessed the impact of complaint barriers on complaint intentions and found them to

prevent at least some customers from complaining to the service provider. These customers might still engage in other types of negative behavior such as opportunism and fraud. Such negative behavioral consequences often relate to stealing from the firm, refusing to pay for a service, faking dissatisfaction, causing service failures, or overstating losses due to service failure (Lovelock and Wirtz 2007). Hence, further research should consider other negative side effects of service failures.

Sixth, with respect to the complaint stimulation phase, research distinguishes between different types of complaint barriers (Mattila and Wirtz 2004), specifically, between complaint communication channels. We would expect different effects of various complaint channels, particularly with regard to interactive complaint channels (e.g., employees asking for feedback, phone hotline) and impersonal complaint channels (e.g., online complaint system, feedback cards). It may be that customers with low levels of affective commitment choose the impersonal channels to vent their anger. In contrast, we might assume that customers with high levels of affective commitment opt for active complaint channels in order to communicate their dissatisfaction.

A final area for future research would be to test in more detail and in different settings the behavioral impact of complaint handling. Studies using behaviors such as recency of last purchase, purchase frequency, and average amount spent are needed to assess valuable suggestions for complaint management in diverse service settings using different outcomes.

Appendix A Scenarios

Scenario A1—Low complaint barriers:

- The company offers several customer feedback channels, for example, online, telephone, print.
- The company provides, free of charge, several contact options, for example, free call number, feedback cards, satisfaction guarantee.
- The company actively and openly seeks feedback from its customers.
- Employees always ask for feedback (e.g., whether everything was satisfactory).

Scenario A2—High complaint barriers:

- There is no easy way for customers to submit a complaint.
- The company provides only an expensive hotline for customer complaints.
- The company is not interested in customer feedback in cases of dissatisfaction.
- Employees never ask for feedback, such as whether everything was satisfactory.

Scenario B2—Low commitment group:

- Customers frequently patronize the restaurant, but do not feel particularly attached.

- Customers feel that the food is satisfactory, but it is not a favorite restaurant.

Scenario B1—High commitment group:

- Customers view the restaurant as a favorite, enjoying the experience there and feeling attached to the restaurant.
- Customers often go there to meet friends.

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Notes

1. Note that we are only interested in comparing individual customer's change in behavior before and after the negative incident. Therefore, other objective purchase data (e.g., frequency) are controlled for, as we only compare individual behaviors at two points in time.
2. A moderated regression analysis confirms results from variance analysis: We find a significant and negative ($\beta = -.112$, $t = -2.230$, $p < .05$) moderating effect of affective commitment on the link between complaint satisfaction and purchase behavior, suggesting that an increase in affective commitment weakens the link between complaint satisfaction and purchase behavior. This result offers additional support for Hypothesis 2, suggesting that the more committed a customer is, the less important complaint satisfaction becomes. We thank one anonymous reviewer for requesting this analysis.
3. We also controlled for some customer demographics and relationship characteristics and find that neither age, gender, income, length of relationship, nor the individual's attitude toward complaining had any significant impact on purchase behavior after the critical incident.

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Bios

Heiner Evanschitzky, PhD, is a professor and chair of marketing at Aston University, UK. His research revolves around service-profit-chain issues with particular interests including service marketing, retailing, relationship marketing, and research methods. His work has been published in leading journals such as *Journal of Marketing*, *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, *Journal of Service Research*, *Journal of Retailing*, *Industrial Marketing Management*, *Journal of Personal Selling and Sales Management*, and *Journal of Business Research*.

Christian Brock, PhD, is an assistant professor of retailing and service marketing at Zeppelin University, Germany. His primary areas of research interest are service management, retail management, and customer relationship management. His work has been published in journals such as *Journal of Service Research* and *Journal of Business & Industrial Marketing*.

Markus Blut, PhD, is an assistant professor of marketing at TU Dortmund University, Germany. His primary areas of research interest are service management, international marketing, and customer relationship management. He has published on these issues in the *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*, *Journal of Service Research*, *Journal of Retailing*, *International Marketing Review*, *Industrial Marketing Management*, and *Journal of Relationship Marketing*.